Corning

3Q26 Preview: Springboard Progress Supports Beat and Raise; However, Springboard Update Likely Needed to Clear High Buy-Side Bar

Neutral

GLW, GLW US
Price (20 Oct 26):$132.26
▼ **Price Target (Dec-27):$165.00**
Prior (Dec-27):$170.00

IT Hardware/ Telecom & Networking Equipment

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Corning shares are trading up +5% since the last earnings print, outperforming the broader market (+3%), Hardware & Networking coverage universe (+0%), and the optical peer group (-1%, or -10% excluding Lumentum), with the move supported by expectations for continued momentum in the Optical-Enterprise business, alongside upside suggested by intra-quarter Optical-Carrier deals. Management further reinforced that view by indicating expectations to track toward the high-end of its prior guidance range in 3Q26 or in other words delivering on its Springboard revenue target of $20 bn a quarter early. This implies high-teens revenue growth in the quarter, a pace management expects to maintain through 2026 and 2027, further cementing the company's trajectory, in our view, toward its internal Springboard revenue target of $30 bn in 2028 (vs. high-confidence target of $27 bn). While the aforementioned positions Corning's upcoming earnings print for a typical beat-and-raise relative to sell-side consensus, we see the setup as more lackluster relative to buy-side expectations that will likely need a more material catalyst, such as a raise to the internal Springboard 2028 revenue target and operating margin target of "at or above 20%," for which we would expect the 3Q26 earnings print might be too soon. On the flip side, we could see Corning adjust its previous target to achieve $1 bn of DCI revenue by 2030, both in terms of timing and magnitude, following deals with AT&T, Verizon, and Zayo, which are additive to the existing agreement with Lumen that is already outpacing original expectations. To that end, despite our positive view on strong demand fundamentals, which we expect to drive positive revisions to sell-side estimates, we would envision more limited upside to buy-side estimates, barring more material updates to Corning's Springboard targets, as those estimates are already tracking materially ahead of the company's overall outlook.

- **3Q26 (Sep-end): Expect modestly better than consensus revenues and margins to support EPS beat.** We forecast revenues of $5.04 bn, narrowly ahead of consensus estimates of $5.02 bn and higher than company guidance of at or slightly above the $4.9 bn-$5.0 bn originally provided in July and informally updated in September. We expect the beat to be primarily driven by revenue momentum in Optical-Enterprise and a rebound in Optical-Carrier sequential growth, offsetting weakness in Glass Innovations where smartphone is partly balanced by stable display performance (see note here). We forecast operating margins of 22.3% (vs. consensus of 21.7%) supported by further mix shift toward Optical and improving economics as Solar manufacturing continues to scale, driving our EPS forecast of $0.90 vs. the consensus estimate of $0.88.
- **4Q26 (Dec-end): Expect revenues and earnings to track slightly ahead of consensus expectations.** We forecast revenue of $5.22 bn, modestly ahead of consensus of $5.2 bn, which is already accounting for management's indication for high-teens growth for 4Q in September, with upside possibly driven by continued momentum in Optical-Enterprise and further recovery in Optical-Carrier. We forecast operating margins of 23.0% (vs. consensus of

Key Changes (FYE Dec)

	Prev	Cur	Δ
Adj. EPS - 27E ($)	3.85	4.25	10.2%

Quarterly Forecasts (FYE Dec)

Adj. EPS ($)

	2025A	2026E	2027E
Q1	0.54	0.70A	0.89
Q2	0.60	0.78A	1.02
Q3	0.67	0.90	1.14
Q4	0.72	0.95	1.19
FY	2.54	3.33	4.25

Style Exposure

Quant Factors	Current %Rank	Hist %Rank (1=Top) 6M	1Y	3Y	5Y
Value	75	83	59	25	21
Growth	11	9	18	94	21
Momentum	50	15	23	82	80
Quality	29	26	32	16	32
Low Vol	59	26	12	6	13
ESGQ	16	23	81	94	97

Sources for: Style Exposure – J.P. Morgan Global Markets Strategy; all other tables are company data and J.P. Morgan estimates.

See page 8 for analyst certification and important disclosures.

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Price Performance



	YTD	1m	3m	12m
Abs	51.0%	-11.9%	-13.6%	55.1%
Rel	38.3%	-12.7%	-17.2%	40.6%

Company Data

Shares O/S (mn)	871
52-week range ($)	271.78-77.39
Market cap ($ mn)	115,198.50
Exchange rate	1.00
Free float (%)	91.9%
3M ADV (mn)	9.98
3M ADV ($ mn)	1,492.6
Volatility (90 Day)	87
Index	S&P 500
BBG ANR (Buy | Hold | Sell)	15|5|0

Key Metrics (FYE Dec)

$ in millions	FY25A	FY26E	FY27E	FY28E
Financial Estimates				
Revenue	16,408	19,340	22,851	28,353
Adj. EBIT	3,160	4,186	5,130	6,750
Adj. EBITDA	4,397	5,652	6,844	8,877
Adj. net income	2,199	2,910	3,705	5,030
Adj. EPS	2.54	3.33	4.25	5.80
BBG EPS	2.52	3.29	4.36	5.89
Cashflow from operations	2,695	4,323	4,923	6,688
FCFF	1,654	2,523	2,681	4,265
Margins and Growth				
Revenue Growth Y/Y (%)	13.4%	17.9%	18.2%	24.1%
EBIT margin	19.3%	21.6%	22.5%	23.8%
EBIT Growth Y/Y (%)	24.9%	32.5%	22.5%	31.6%
EBITDA margin	26.8%	29.2%	30.0%	31.3%
EBITDA Growth Y/Y (%)	17.0%	28.6%	21.1%	29.7%
Net margin	13.4%	15.0%	16.2%	17.7%
Adj. EPS growth	29.1%	31.2%	27.5%	36.5%
Ratios				
Adj. tax rate	19.2%	18.8%	18.5%	18.5%
Interest cover	14.8	19.4	24.4	31.7
Net debt/Equity	0.6	0.4	0.3	0.2
Net debt/EBITDA	1.6	1.0	0.7	0.4
ROE	18.8%	22.1%	24.7%	29.2%
Valuation				
FCFF yield	1.4%	2.2%	2.3%	3.7%
Dividend yield	0.8%	0.8%	0.9%	1.0%
EV/Revenue	7.5	6.3	5.4	4.3
EV/EBITDA	27.8	21.7	17.9	13.8
Adj. P/E	52.1	39.7	31.2	22.8

Summary Investment Thesis and Valuation

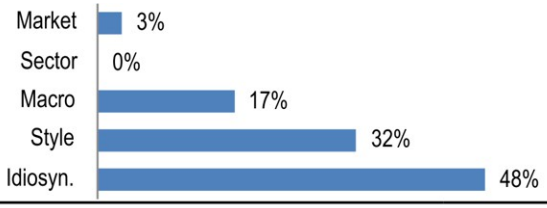
Investment Thesis

We are maintaining our Neutral rating on Corning on the balance of a strong underlying optical demand environment where the company is well positioned to benefit given its leadership in fiber cables and connectors both inside and outside the data center, offset by a lofty valuation premium that investors are ascribing to the shares that in our view embeds blue-sky scenarios and leaves little margin for error on risks related to optical capacity and adoption as well as the remaining portion of the business tied to non-optical markets.

Valuation

We are lowering our December 2027 price target to $165 from $170, based on valuing our 2028E EPS estimate at a 27x P/E multiple (from 30x prior). We believe the 27x multiple is more in-line with the broader optical peer group which has traded lower in recent weeks, while still accounting for Corning's unique positioning as a U.S.-based, vertically integrated, large-scale supplier of optical fiber cable and connectors, products that are well positioned to benefit from the AI infrastructure investment backdrop.

Performance Drivers



Factors	6M Corr	1Y Corr
Market: MSCI US	0.13	0.19
Sect: Technology	-0.05	0.04
Ind: Tech Hard Equip	0.15	0.17
Macro:		
Crude Oil	-0.38	-0.36
US 10yr Breakeven	-0.39	-0.29
US 10yr yield	-0.36	-0.28
Quant Styles:		
Momentum	0.59	0.54
Size	0.45	0.43
Growth	-0.31	-0.23

Source: J.P. Morgan Global Markets Strategy for Performance Drivers; company data, Bloomberg Finance L.P. and J.P. Morgan estimates for all other tables. Note: Price history may not be complete or exact.

22.6%) supported by 30%+ incremental margins, driving our EPS forecast of $0.95 vs. consensus estimate of $0.93.

- **Favorable forecast revisions from industry analysts bode well for Optical.** LightCounting revised its TRx market outlook higher by roughly +40% for 2028, on account of suppliers ramping much faster than expected. That said, the CPO and NPO forecasts did not change meaningfully and most of the revision came from 800G TRx. Tangentially, 650 Group revised its DCI market outlook by +15% for 2028 (see note here).
- **Section 232 action likely to have gradual impact on Solar segment.** While minimum import prices and tariffs are expected to take effect on December 4th, we expect the benefits to the Solar business to be modest near-term, with the majority of the improvement still concentrated in the ongoing production ramp. Additionally, Corning pulled forward the timeline for Solar to reach corporate-average or better profitability to the end of 2027, from "by 2028" prior, driven by improved timing for bringing wafer and module capacity to full output and removing ramp-related costs, with the minimum input prices and tariffs provide added support.

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Investment Thesis, Valuation and Risks

Corning *(Neutral; Price Target: $165.00)*

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Corning P/E-Based Target Analysis

$ in Millions, except per share amounts

	NTM Qtrs 1-4	2028E
JPM Net Income	3,079	5,030
Add Back: SBC	295	315
JPM Net Income ex SBC	3,374	5,345
JPM EPS	$3.52	$5.80
JPM EPS ex SBC	**$3.86**	**$6.16**
P/E Multiple	38x	
P/E Multiple (ex-SBC)	34x	
JPM P/E Multiple		27x
Implied Equity Value	115,198	143,257
Average Diluted Share Count	871	868
Implied Share Price	**$132.3**	**$165.0**
Current Value per Share	$132.26	$132.26
Upside vs. Current		25%
Memo:		
(-) Net Cash/(Debt)	(7,218)	(3,411)
Enterprise Value	**122,416**	**146,668**
JPM EBITDA	5,901	8,869
Implied EV/EBITDA	*20.7x*	*16.5x*

Source: J.P. Morgan estimates.

Risks to Rating and Price Target

Industry Upside Risks

Display pricing could strengthen more than expected. Despite solid growth in displays, including glass used in consumer devices over the last few years, pricing has historically declined, though in more recent years has shown signs of stabilization and improvement. Nonetheless, greater than expected strength in pricing for the display market would likely lead to upside to our forecasts.

Industry Downside Risks

Delays in the copper-to-optical transition in the scale-up domain. A slower than expected adoption of optics inside the rack, driven by customer architecture choices, supply chain challenges, or innovations that push out the photonics roadmap, would likely lead to downside to our forecasts.

Company Upside Risks

Supply chain leadership in optical fiber cable and connectors. Corning is one of the few vertically integrated U.S. optical companies, spanning raw fiber to cables and connectors. Better-than-expected market share in passive optical content due to better cost, reliability of supply, or U.S.-sourced manufacturing could drive upside to our estimates.

Faster than expected adoption of Hemlock's solar solutions. We expect Hemlock's solar solutions to find increasing adoption as customers look to benefit from U.S. federal support, which is encouraging domestic substitution. Faster than expected adoption could drive upside to our estimates.

Company Downside Risks

Memory headwinds could adversely impact unit volumes in Corning's Glass Innovations segment. Continued growth in memory prices would alter the cost structures for end-markets like TVs and mobile phones, which can reduce demand for display panels and, in turn, adversely impact unit volumes in Corning's Glass Innovations segment.

Drop performance requirements from Gorilla cover glass could reach a ceiling. One of the primary drivers of the premium pricing for Gorilla cover glass is the superior drop performance relative to the competition, which Corning improves further with every generation of the product. However, customers could see further improvements beyond a certain level of drop performance as unnecessary and could be unwilling to pay continued premiums for improvements beyond a certain level, limiting ASP opportunity for Corning.

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Corning: Summary of Financials

Income Statement - Annual	FY25A	FY26E	FY27E	FY28E	FY29E
Revenue	**16,408**	**19,340**	**22,851**	**28,353**	**32,869**
COGS	(10,115)	(11,681)	(13,769)	(17,045)	(19,744)
Gross profit	**6,293**	**7,658**	**9,082**	**11,308**	**13,125**
SG&A	(2,028)	(2,304)	(2,548)	(2,935)	(3,361)
Adj. EBITDA	**4,397**	**5,652**	**6,844**	**8,877**	**10,442**
D&A	(1,237)	(1,466)	(1,714)	(2,126)	(2,465)
Adj. EBIT	**3,160**	**4,186**	**5,130**	**6,750**	**7,976**
Net Interest	(298)	(292)	(280)	(280)	(280)
Adj. PBT	**2,903**	**3,861**	**4,834**	**6,454**	**7,680**
Tax	(558)	(726)	(894)	(1,194)	(1,421)
Minority Interest	(146)	(225)	(235)	(230)	(230)
Adj. Net Income	**2,199**	**2,910**	**3,705**	**5,030**	**6,030**
Reported EPS	2.54	3.33	4.25	5.80	7.00
Adj. EPS	**2.54**	**3.33**	**4.25**	**5.80**	**7.00**
DPS	**1.12**	**1.12**	**1.23**	**1.36**	**1.49**
Payout ratio	44.1%	33.6%	29.0%	23.4%	21.3%
Shares outstanding	867	874	873	868	862

Balance Sheet & Cash Flow Statement	FY25A	FY26E	FY27E	FY28E	FY29E
Cash and cash equivalents	1,526	2,775	3,353	5,013	7,599
Accounts receivable	2,779	2,858	3,431	4,312	4,836
Inventories	3,077	3,450	4,144	5,183	6,103
Other current assets	7,410	8,363	9,630	11,551	12,994
Current assets	**8,936**	**11,138**	**12,983**	**16,564**	**20,593**
PP&E	14,825	15,446	16,202	16,727	16,911
LT investments	0	0	0	0	0
Other non current assets	4,069	4,026	4,026	4,026	4,026
Total assets	**30,976**	**33,696**	**36,297**	**40,403**	**44,616**
Short term borrowings	804	668	668	668	668
Payables	1,934	2,070	2,279	2,851	3,197
Other short term liabilities	2,890	3,094	3,656	4,537	5,259
Current liabilities	**5,628**	**5,832**	**6,603**	**8,055**	**9,124**
Long-term debt	7,630	7,756	7,756	7,756	7,756
Other long term liabilities	13,041	13,808	13,808	13,808	13,808
Total liabilities	**18,669**	**19,640**	**20,411**	**21,863**	**22,932**
Shareholders' equity	12,307	14,055	15,885	18,539	21,684
Minority interests	-	-	-	-	-
Total liabilities & equity	**30,976**	**33,696**	**36,297**	**40,403**	**44,616**
BVPS	**14.39**	**16.35**	**18.52**	**21.74**	**25.61**
y/y Growth	*10.9%*	*13.6%*	*13.3%*	*17.4%*	*17.8%*
Net debt/(cash)	6,908	5,649	5,071	3,411	825
Cash flow from operating activities	**2,695**	**4,323**	**4,923**	**6,688**	**8,120**
o/w Depreciation & amortization	1,237	1,466	1,714	2,126	2,465
o/w Changes in working capital	0	0	0	0	0
Cash flow from investing activities	**(1,243)**	**(1,845)**	**(2,470)**	**(2,651)**	**(2,649)**
o/w Capital expenditure	(1,282)	(2,037)	(2,470)	(2,651)	(2,649)
as % of sales	*7.8%*	*10.5%*	*10.8%*	*9.4%*	*8.1%*
Cash flow from financing activities	**(1,672)**	**(1,262)**	**(1,875)**	**(2,376)**	**(2,885)**
o/w Dividends paid	(999)	(985)	(1,075)	(1,176)	(1,285)
o/w Net debt issued/(repaid)	(55)	(242)	0	0	0
Net change in cash	**(202)**	**1,209**	**578**	**1,661**	**2,586**
Adj. Free cash flow to firm	**1,654**	**2,523**	**2,681**	**4,265**	**5,699**
y/y Growth	*38.0%*	*52.6%*	*6.3%*	*59.1%*	*33.6%*

Income Statement - Quarterly	1Q26A	2Q26A	3Q26E	4Q26E
Revenue	**4,345A**	**4,738A**	**5,041**	**5,216**
COGS	(2,645)A	(2,864)A	(3,024)	(3,148)
Gross profit	**1,700A**	**1,874A**	**2,016**	**2,068**
SG&A	(546)A	(590)A	(600)	(569)
Adj. EBITDA	**1,210A**	**1,357A**	**1,497**	**1,588**
D&A	(334)A	(368)A	(373)	(391)
Adj. EBIT	**876A**	**989A**	**1,124**	**1,197**
Net Interest	(70)A	(82)A	(70)	(70)
Adj. PBT	**797A**	**898A**	**1,045**	**1,121**
Tax	(157)A	(168)A	(193)	(207)
Minority Interest	(28)A	(50)A	(65)	(82)
Adj. Net Income	**612A**	**680A**	**787**	**832**
Reported EPS	0.70A	0.78A	0.90	0.95
Adj. EPS	**0.70A**	**0.78A**	**0.90**	**0.95**
DPS	**0.28A**	**0.28A**	**0.28**	**0.28**
Payout ratio	39.8%A	36.0%A	31.2%	29.5%
Shares outstanding	871A	875A	875	875

Ratio Analysis	FY25A	FY26E	FY27E	FY28E	FY29E
Gross margin	38.4%	39.6%	39.7%	39.9%	39.9%
EBITDA margin	26.8%	29.2%	30.0%	31.3%	31.8%
EBIT margin	19.3%	21.6%	22.5%	23.8%	24.3%
Net profit margin	13.4%	15.0%	16.2%	17.7%	18.3%
ROE	18.8%	22.1%	24.7%	29.2%	30.0%
ROA	7.5%	9.0%	10.6%	13.1%	14.2%
ROCE	13.1%	15.7%	17.9%	21.5%	22.8%
SG&A/Sales	12.4%	11.9%	11.2%	10.4%	10.2%
Net debt/equity	0.6	0.4	0.3	0.2	0.0
P/E (x)	52.1	39.7	31.2	22.8	18.9
P/BV (x)	9.2	8.1	7.1	6.1	5.2
EV/EBITDA (x)	27.8	21.7	17.9	13.8	11.7
Dividend Yield	0.8%	0.8%	0.9%	1.0%	1.1%
Sales/Assets (x)	0.6	0.6	0.7	0.7	0.8
Interest cover (x)	14.8	19.4	24.4	31.7	37.3
Operating leverage	185.8%	181.7%	124.2%	131.2%	114.0%
Revenue y/y Growth	13.4%	17.9%	18.2%	24.1%	15.9%
EBITDA y/y Growth	17.0%	28.6%	21.1%	29.7%	17.6%
Tax rate	19.2%	18.8%	18.5%	18.5%	18.5%
Adj. Net Income y/y Growth	29.4%	32.4%	27.3%	35.8%	19.9%
EPS y/y Growth	29.1%	31.2%	27.5%	36.5%	20.7%
DPS y/y Growth	0.0%	0.0%	10.0%	10.0%	10.0%

Source: Company reports and J.P. Morgan estimates.
Note: $ in millions (except per-share data).Fiscal year ends Dec. o/w - out of which

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Corning (GLW, GLW US) Price Chart



Source: Bloomberg Finance L.P. and J.P. Morgan; price data adjusted for stock splits and dividends.
Initiated coverage Aug 12, 1999. All share prices are as of market close on the previous business day.

Date	Rating	Price ($)	Price Target ($)
24-Oct-23	N	26.93	31
08-Jan-24	N	30.57	33
30-Jan-24	N	31.15	34
11-Apr-24	N	31.95	36
30-Apr-24	N	31.78	37
30-May-24	OW	35.55	43
09-Jul-24	OW	43.05	47
29-Jul-24	OW	42.85	55
29-Oct-24	OW	46.84	60
26-Jan-25	OW	54.25	62
17-Apr-25	OW	41.28	50
29-Apr-25	OW	44.10	52
17-Jul-25	OW	52.97	62
25-Jul-25	OW	55.72	65
29-Jul-25	OW	55.41	72
22-Sep-25	OW	79.56	85
28-Oct-25	OW	89.37	100
27-Jan-26	OW	94.95	115
16-Apr-26	N	168.27	175
07-May-26	N	181.57	185
16-Jul-26	N	174.41	200
29-Jul-26	N	126.01	170

The chart(s) show J.P. Morgan's continuing coverage of the stocks; the current analysts may or may not have covered it over the entire period.
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